

65 Michal

Saul's daughter, who loved David, saved his life, and later despised him.

Michal, King Saul's younger daughter, loved David, and Saul used her love as a trap. When her father's men came to kill David, Michal let him down through a window and bought him time with a trick. But while David was a fugitive, Saul gave her to another man. Years later David demanded her back, and her second husband followed her weeping. When David danced before the ark, Michal looked down from a window and despised him. Bitterness had closed her heart to joy.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Mikhal</i> ; meaning uncertain, often linked with Michael
<i>Family</i>	Younger daughter of Saul; sister of Merab and Jonathan (1 Samuel 14:49)
<i>Husbands</i>	David; then Phalti son of Laish (1 Samuel 18:27; 25:44)
<i>When</i>	Saul's reign and David's early reign, c. 1050–1000 BC
<i>Key places</i>	Gibeah, Gallim, Bahurim, Jerusalem
<i>Key people</i>	Saul, David, Jonathan, Phaltiel, Abner
<i>Children</i>	"No child unto the day of her death" (2 Samuel 6:23)
<i>New Testament</i>	Not named

"And as the ark of the LORD came into the city of David, Michal Saul's daughter looked through a window, and saw king David leaping and dancing before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart."

2 Samuel 6:16, KJV

The life of Michal

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). Her story runs from Saul's court to the early years of David's reign in Jerusalem.

Saul's court	Loves David "Michal Saul's daughter loved David," and Saul is pleased. He asks as a bride-price proof that David has killed a hundred Philistines, hoping David will die. David brings double, and they marry. <i>1 Samuel 18:20-28</i>
One night	Saves David's life Saul sends men to watch David's house and kill him in the morning. Michal lets David down through a window, puts an image in his bed with goats' hair at its head, and says he is sick. <i>1 Samuel 19:11-17</i>
While David is a fugitive	Given to another man With David on the run in the wilderness, Saul gives Michal as wife to another man, Phalti son of Laish, of Gallim. Scripture does not record what Michal thought of it. <i>1 Samuel 25:44</i>
David at Hebron	Taken back When Abner offers to bring Israel over to David, David demands Michal's return. Ish-bosheth takes her from Phaltiel, who follows weeping as far as Bahurim until Abner sends him home. <i>2 Samuel 3:12-16</i>
In Jerusalem	Despises David As the ark comes into the city, Michal sees David dancing and despises him. She mocks him when he comes home, and David answers her sharply. <i>2 Samuel 6:16, 20-23</i>

Group notes

Key activities

2 Samuel 21:8 in the KJV mentions "the five sons of Michal the daughter of Saul" brought up for Adriel. But 1 Samuel 18:19 says Merab married Adriel, and 2 Samuel 6:23 says Michal had no child. A few Hebrew manuscripts and some Greek copies read Merab in 21:8, and most modern translations follow them. Others explain "Michal" as the aunt who raised them.

- 1

Loved David. Scripture says twice that Michal loved David, and Saul saw it. *1 Samuel 18:20, 28*
- 2

Chose her husband over her father. She warned David, "If thou save not thy life to night, to morrow thou shalt be slain." *1 Samuel 19:11*
- 3

Deceived Saul's men. She helped David escape through a window and used an image in the bed to delay the soldiers. *1 Samuel 19:12-16*
- 4

Lied to protect herself. When Saul confronted her, she claimed David had threatened to kill her. *1 Samuel 19:17*
- 5

Was passed between men. She was given to Phalti and then taken back to David, with no word of her own recorded. *1 Samuel 25:44; 2 Samuel 3:13-16*
- 6

Despised worship. She scorned David's dancing: "How glorious was the king of Israel to day." David replied, "I will yet be more vile than thus." *2 Samuel 6:20-22*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Michal.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 14:49	She is named as Saul's younger daughter.
1 Samuel 18:20–28; 19:11–17; 25:44	Her marriage to David, her rescue of him, and her marriage to Phalti.
2 Samuel 3:13–16	She is returned to David.
2 Samuel 6:16–23	and 1 Chronicles 15:29. She despises David's dancing before the ark.
2 Samuel 21:8	KJV names her; most read Merab (see key activities note)
Echo: Joshua 2:15	Rahab also let men down through a window
Echo: Psalm 150:4	"Praise him with the timbrel and dance"

New Testament

Echo: Mark 14:3–9	Jesus defends a woman criticized for her costly worship
Echo: Luke 15:25–32	The elder brother refuses to join the celebration

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Michal do for David in 1 Samuel 19, and what did she say to him in 2 Samuel 6?
2. *Understand:* What might have happened in Michal's heart between those two scenes?
3. *Apply:* Michal watched worship from a window. What keeps you at a distance from wholehearted worship?
4. *Apply:* Is there an old hurt that is making you critical of someone else's joy? What step toward healing could you take?